

Lab 1 - Establish the Layout Requirement from a Client Brief

Topic 01: Get Started on InDesign | LO1 | TGS-2021007827

The Situation

You are the junior layout designer at Harmony Petals, a Singapore florist with three retail outlets. The marketing manager, Priya, forwards an e-mail brief at 9.40 am: "We need an A5 landscape promotional flyer for the Mid-Autumn range, full-colour, printed both sides on 200 gsm art card, 5,000 copies, litho at Sun Ray Printers. Photos bleed off all four edges. Please confirm the specification before you start." Priya has not stated the bleed, the margins or the colour mode. Sun Ray Printers' website states a 3 mm bleed and a 5 mm minimum safety margin. Getting this wrong costs the 5,000-copy print run.

At a Glance

Learning outcome	LO1
Objective	Establish drawing and layout requirements from a client brief and translate them into a written InDesign document specification (TSC A1, A2).
You will produce	A completed Document Specification Sheet (trim, bleed, slug, margins, columns, colour mode, resolution, output) signed off before any file is created, plus InDesign preferences set to millimetres.
Tools and panels	Adobe InDesign Document Specification Sheet Preferences > Units & Increments
Starter InDesign file	restaurant-menu.indd
Final filename	Lab-01-Completed.indd

What You Will Do

Interrogate a real client brief, identify what is specified and what is missing, and produce a completed Document Specification Sheet. You then set the InDesign application preferences (units in millimetres) that every subsequent lab depends on.

Phase 1 - Prepare and Baseline

1. Read this guide completely, then duplicate restaurant-menu.indd as Lab-01-Working.indd.
2. Create an Evidence/ folder beside the working file.
3. Open the working copy and capture the starting Pages, Links or Preflight panel most relevant to the task.
4. Keep every linked asset inside this lab folder: never relink to Downloads, Desktop or a network path.

Starter role: Existing publication to audit against the client brief before any production work begins.

Phase 2 - Build

Step-by-Step Procedure

1. Open restaurant-menu.indd as a production-audit sample. Use File > Document Setup, Window > Links and Window > Output > Preflight to record its current page, link and output state before interpreting the new client brief.

File > Document Setup | Window > Links | Window > Output > Preflight

2. Record the publication's purpose, primary audience, delivery medium, accessibility needs and approval owner. Flag any image, font, model-release or location-release rights that still require confirmation.

Brief audit: purpose | audience | medium | accessibility | rights

3. Read the brief and list every stated requirement - size, orientation, colour, stock, quantity, print process, finishing.
4. Identify the missing specifications. The brief omits bleed, margins, slug and colour mode; these must be confirmed with the printer, not assumed.
5. Look up Sun Ray Printers' specification: 3 mm bleed on all four sides, 5 mm minimum safety margin from trim, PDF/X-1a supply.
6. Compute the sizes. A5 landscape trim = 210 x 148 mm. Add 3 mm bleed on all sides for the artwork area = 216 x 154 mm.

Trim 210 x 148 mm | Bleed 3 mm | Artwork 216 x 154 mm

7. Decide the colour mode from the output: litho press = CMYK. Set image resolution at 300 ppi effective at final size.
8. Complete the Document Specification Sheet and have it checked by the trainer, acting as Priya, before proceeding.
9. Close all documents. Choose Edit (Windows) or InDesign (macOS) > Preferences > Units & Increments and set Horizontal and Vertical to Millimeters.

Preferences > Units & Increments > Millimeters

10. In Preferences > File Handling, enable Auto-activate Adobe Fonts so missing fonts are resolved automatically.

Preferences > File Handling > Auto-activate Adobe Fonts

Verify Your Work

- ☐ Done when: Your Specification Sheet states trim 210 x 148 mm, bleed 3 mm, artwork 216 x 154 mm, CMYK, 300 ppi, PDF/X-1a - and the InDesign rulers now read in millimetres.

Evidence and Submission

- [] Completed specification sheet
- [] Annotated audit screenshot
- [] Approved output decision
- [] Final native file saved as Lab-01-Completed.indd
- [] All linked assets remain inside this lab folder or its subfolders
- [] No overset text, missing fonts or missing links remain unless the task explicitly asks you to diagnose them

Recovery Path

1. If the working file is damaged, close it without saving and duplicate restaurant-menu.indd again.
2. If links are missing, use the Links panel Relink command and select the matching file inside this lab folder.
3. If fonts are missing, activate Adobe Fonts or substitute an approved font, then check for reflow and overset text.
4. Re-run the verification gate and recapture evidence after recovery.

If It Doesn't Work

If the rulers still show picas or inches, you changed preferences with a document open - that only changes the current document. Close all documents and set the preference again to make it the application default.

Stretch Challenge

Identify one accessibility risk and one rights or licensing risk in the supplied menu, then record the corrective action in the brief.

Discussion Questions

1. Which four items in Priya's brief are production specifications, and which two are still missing?
2. Why is 3 mm bleed required when the photographs are described as running 'off all four edges'?
3. The job is litho-printed. What colour mode must the document use, and what would happen at the printer if RGB were used instead?
4. The flyer is A5 landscape. State the trim size in millimetres, and the document size including bleed.
5. Why must units be set to millimetres with no document open, rather than after creating the file?

Reference Artwork

[!Lab 1](#)

Reference Basis

ACP guide domain 1: purpose, audience, design plans, rights, terminology and design principles.

Current Adobe Help: <https://helpx.adobe.com/indesign/desktop.html>

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